

All food imported into Australia must comply with Australian food standards and requirements for safety. This includes compliance with:

We monitor imported food to check it meets these requirements through a risk-based inspection scheme called the [Imported Food Inspection Scheme \(IFIS\)](#).

The Department of Home Affairs' [Integrated Cargo System \(ICS\)](#) refers shipments of imported food to us for inspection and testing.

Notification of inspection

We issue a Food Control Certificate (FCC) to let you know your imported food needs to be inspected and if any tests apply. The food to be inspected must remain on hold. You cannot distribute it.

Food Control Certificate

We use FCCs to communicate directions to importers.

The initial FCC sets out:

- which lines of the import entry will be inspected and must be held
- the location the goods are to be held for inspection; this is the importer's premises unless the importer requests the location be changed
- which lines of the import entry will not be inspected
- directions for booking an inspection
- what tests are required
- if any food in the consignment is subject to a [holding order](#)
- any additional directions.

We may issue additional FCCs to advise:

- if we need further information
- when your laboratory nomination has been accepted.

Where the consignment has CONDCLEAR status in ICS, the goods can be released to the importer's control while awaiting the FCC.

Nominate a laboratory

If your food needs to be tested, the FCC will instruct you to nominate a laboratory. The laboratory must be an appointed analyst under the IFIS.

You can book an inspection once a laboratory advises you that they have accepted your nomination.

Book an inspection

If your food has been referred for inspection, you will need to book an inspection with us.

If your food has also been referred for testing, you will need to nominate a laboratory before you book an inspection.

Complete and submit the [Request for Inspection Form](#) to book your inspection.

Virtual inspections

We can now virtually inspect eligible [imported food](#) that has been referred for label and visual inspection.

A virtual inspection is conducted in real time using Microsoft Teams.

Only food classified as surveillance food is eligible for a virtual label and visual inspection. The following surveillance foods are not eligible:

- formulated supplementary sport foods
- food subject to a holding order
- food subject to analytical testing.

Risk foods are not eligible for label and visual inspections except for permitted [kava](#) products.

Virtual engagement with the imported food industry has increased steadily since its introduction, with over 2000 virtual inspections conducted in 2023.

Watch the video below to find out more:

The department is now offering virtual label and visual inspections of eligible surveillance food under the Imported Food Inspection Scheme (IFIS) as a permanent option for importers. During a virtual inspection, an authorised officer from the department connects with an importer online using Microsoft Teams to conduct the inspection remotely. These inspections reduce delays, allowing for continuity of supply for food importers.

Virtual engagement with the imported food industry has increased steadily since its introduction, with over 500 virtual inspections conducted over the first 12 months.

The Top 5 Food Types regularly assessed and cleared via virtual inspection include:

- Alcohol for retail sale
- Bulk food ingredients such as juice concentrates for further processing
- Noodles and Pasta
- Confectionary
- Tea and coffee

To participate in a virtual inspection, importers or an authorised representative must express interest and conduct connectivity with the department prior to booking a virtual inspection.

Importers or an authorised representative must have suitable IT equipment and internet access at the inspection location including access to Microsoft Teams to connect with the department.

The importer or representative undertaking the virtual inspection will be required to follow directions of the authorised officer, including selecting samples for inspection as directed by the authorised officer and holding each to the camera for inspection.

This initiative offers many benefits to industry, including:

- Reduced inspection delays
- Provides an alternative inspection method for suitable food
- Lower inspection charges compared to physical inspections

To participate, importers should email the department via the email address shown on the screen. The department will then:

- send you the eligibility checklist for virtual inspections to complete
- provide you with the Imported Food virtual inspection guidelines

You can also refer to our imported food label and visual virtual inspections fact sheet.

To register your business, email Importedfood-postinspection@aff.gov.au

Download

[Imported food label and visual virtual inspections \(PDF 336 KB\)](#) [Imported food label and visual virtual inspections \(DOCX 228 KB\)](#)

If you have difficulty accessing these files, please contact foodimp@aff.gov.au for assistance.

Imported food inspection

Make sure the food to be inspected is visible and easy to access and the required documentation is ready for the authorised officer.

At inspection, we visually assess your food and check the label to make sure it complies with Australian requirements. If testing is required, we will take samples of your food.

If you are not prepared for the inspection or you don't follow our instructions, we may cancel your inspection but still charge you for it. If this occurs, you will need to re-book an inspection.

Imported Food Inspection Report

We issue an electronic Imported Food Inspection Report (eIFIR) at the end of your inspection. The eIFIR sets out:

- how many samples we took for testing
- if you can release the food or not.

The eIFIR is also sent to your nominated laboratory to let them know your samples are ready to be collected from us.

Imported Food Inspection Advice

If your inspection is only a label and visual assessment, you will be issued with an Imported Food Inspection Advice (IFIA) at the end of inspection or shortly after.

If samples have been taken for testing, the IFIA will be sent to you once testing results are known.

The IFIA will tell you if your food has:

- passed assessment and can be released
- failed inspection.

If your food fails inspection

If your food fails inspection, the IFIA will tell you the reasons it has failed. The food cannot be released.

The IFIA will tell you:

- what to do with the food, either
 - relabel
 - dispose of or re-export your food under the supervision of an authorised offer
- how to book another inspection, and when this needs to occur.

Fees

See our [charging guidelines](#) for the standard charges for imported food inspections.

Your nominated laboratory sets their charges for testing. They will invoice you directly.

Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/biosecurity-trade/import/goods/food/inspection-testing>